

# Blàths

*warmth · blossom*

/blas/ · “blaas”

## Skye Community Sauna

Project overview: concept, team, brand, funding, financials and growth strategy.

*Blàths à fuachd.*

“Warmth out of cold,” the heat the plunge gives back



## 01 The Concept

A community-first outdoor wood-fired sauna business on the Isle of Skye, with ambition to expand to the West Coast mainland. Inspired by Kiln Sauna (Cornwall). Mobile trailer-mounted, wood-fired, off-grid units sited at harbours and coastal locations with direct sea/loch access for cold plunge.

*Blàths à fuachd.*

"Warmth out of cold," the heat the plunge gives back.

Core ethos: locals get genuine priority and meaningful pricing benefit, a direct response to Skye's overtourism problem. Not a tourist concession dressed up as community. Community pricing and membership written into company articles from day one.

2

SAUNAS AT LAUNCH

£500k

MAX SEIS RAISE

£90k/yr

PROJECTED GROSS REVENUE

5 yrs

MAX CAPEX PAYBACK

## 02 The Team

**Charles Solanki**

*Co-Founder · Strategy & Fundraising*

Falmouth-based, Kiln Sauna user, driving vision and investor relations.

**Dec Dutfield**

*Co-Founder · Operations, Maintenance, Team Management*

Plumber; Head of Maintenance at Wickman Hotels (Cuillin Hills + Flodigarry). Has personally built saunas. Island supply chain knowledge.

**Ed Wickman**

*Hospitality Partner / Non-Exec*

Owner, Wickman Hotels: Cuillin Hills Hotel (Portree, top 10% TripAdvisor worldwide) and Flodigarry Hotel (Victorian estate, foot of the Quiraing). Thousands of guests/year.

**Becky Solanki**

*Brand & Marketing*

MD, Good Culture (goodcultureinc.com): talent, partnership and cultural strategy. 20+ yrs experience. Clients: Disney, Barbour, Creed, The Dalmore, Glastonbury.

**Kirsty MacDougall**

*Gaelic Cultural Advisor*

Dec's fiancée. Gaelic lecturer and fluent speaker. Formal advisor role for brand language, signage and cultural authenticity.

## 03 Brand Direction: Blàths

Blàths is the human, hospitable direction: warmth as a feeling rather than a temperature. The mark is a sprig of bog cotton (canach an t-slàibh), the white tuft that blossoms across Highland moors in summer, soft and local, a world away from spa lotus motifs. Instrument Serif gives it an unhurried, almost handwritten editorial grace, warmed by amber and dusty heather.

| Name   | Gaelic meaning   | Pronunciation | Status                             |
|--------|------------------|---------------|------------------------------------|
| Teine  | Fire             | CHEH-nyuh     | Elemental direction (not selected) |
| Cuan   | Ocean / sea      | KOO-an        | Maritime direction (not selected)  |
| Blàths | Warmth / blossom | blaas         | Selected direction (this document) |

Action: UKIPO trademark check required on Blàths (class 44 health/beauty, class 43 hospitality) before brand investment proceeds.

## 04 Pricing Model

| Customer                                 | Session price     | Membership                       |
|------------------------------------------|-------------------|----------------------------------|
| Local residents (Skye postcode verified) | £8–10 / person    | ~£30–40/month unlimited off-peak |
| Visitors                                 | £16–20 / person   | Gift vouchers, bundles           |
| Private hire (exclusive)                 | £80–120 / session | Premium packages £150–250        |

Minimum 30% of session capacity reserved for local bookings. Community sessions blocked before tourist bookings open. Written into company articles.

## 05 Sites

### Recommended Launch Sites: Two-Site Start

Site 1: Portree Harbour / Bayfield (anchor site)

- Highest footfall on Skye. Zero sauna presence currently.
- Cuillin Hills Hotel overlooks the bay; Ed's guests are a 10 minute walk away.
- Cruise ship day visitors, island residents, passing trade.
- Key contact: Highland Council Harbourmaster + Portree & Braes Community Trust.
- Note: sailing club planning application filed, so an alternative Portree site or positioning is required.

#### Site 2: Broadford / Uig (to be confirmed)

- Staffin Harbour now occupied by Staffin Sea Sauna; original Site 2 revised.
- Broadford Bay: gateway to Skye, year-round community base, pier infrastructure.
- Uig Ferry Terminal: CMAL surplus site opportunity scored on community benefit.
- See companion Site Shortlist document for full analysis.

## Later Phase Sites

- Dunvegan / Loch Dunvegan: MacLeod Estate land, iconic, high seasonal footfall
- Elgol / Loch Scavaig: premium, remote, dramatic Cuillin views, hero flagship unit
- Carbost / Loch Harport: Sauna Na Mara already there; monitor

## 06 Competitive Landscape

Eight operators identified on Skye and nearby west coast. Market is emerging, not saturated; the East Coast (Fife / St Andrews) has 15+ operators for comparison. Every current west coast competitor is a single-unit, solo operation.

| Operator                   | Location                 | Model                                    | Threat level             |
|----------------------------|--------------------------|------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| <b>Staffin Sea Sauna</b>   | Staffin Harbour, NE Skye | Community membership, established        | Direct at Staffin        |
| <b>Sauna Na Mara</b>       | Carbost, Skye            | Community model, Gaelic name, very new   | Moderate (Carbost only)  |
| <b>Sál Sauna</b>           | Ord Beach, south Sleat   | Solo operator, remote, retreat feel      | Low                      |
| <b>Suilanu</b>             | Private croft, Skye      | Women-only retreats, sold out            | None (different product) |
| <b>Teas Mòr (Knoydart)</b> | Long Beach, Knoydart     | Boat-access peninsula, great Gaelic name | None                     |

| Operator         | Location            | Model                               | Threat level |
|------------------|---------------------|-------------------------------------|--------------|
| Applecross Sauna | Applecross Bay      | Community/social enterprise, mobile | Low          |
| Fire & Steam     | Gairloch / Shildaig | Mobile, hotel-attached              | None         |
| Great Glen Sauna | Fort William area   | Horse box trailer, inland           | None         |

## Key Competitive Gaps

- 01 Portree: completely unoccupied by any operator
- 02 Nobody operates at scale (every competitor is single-unit, solo operator)
- 03 Enormous brand quality gap: no west coast operator has anything approaching Good Culture-level brand capability
- 04 Authentic Gaelic depth (vs. Gaelic names used decoratively)
- 05 Hospitality distribution: no competitor has a hotel partner with thousands of guests per year

Grant application framing: "Eight operators now active across the west coast, yet Portree, the island's principal settlement, remains completely unserved."

## 07 Legal & Planning

|                              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Landowner / foreshore</b> | Most Skye beaches = Crown Estate Scotland foreshore. Foreshore licence required for commercial use below the mean high-water line. Managing agents: Bidwells. Keeping the unit on pier hardstanding above high-water line avoids this requirement. |
| <b>Planning permission</b>   | Truly mobile trailer saunas may not require planning permission. Long-term fixed siting = likely planning consent needed. Always submit a pre-application development enquiry to Highland Council before committing to a site.                     |
| <b>Receptive precedent</b>   | Highland Council recommended approval of a community sauna at Bellfield Park, Inverness; directly analogous and useful to cite.                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Key risk</b>              | Retrospective planning refusals in England (Swansea, Dorset). Always secure permissions before operating. Never rely on tolerance.                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Site type preference</b>  | Harbour/slipway locations significantly easier for permissions than open beach. Prefer pier hardstanding.                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Designations</b>          | Check NatureScot designations for any specific site before progressing. Skye has many: NSA, SSSI, SAC, SPA and Wild Land Areas can all stack on a single site.                                                                                     |

## 08 Funding Strategy

### SEIS Equity Raise

|                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Eligibility</b>    | Likely eligible (leisure services = qualifying trade). Key risk: 'hotel or comparable establishment' exclusion; unlikely to apply but must get SEIS Advance Assurance from HMRC before issuing shares. |
| <b>Maximum raise</b>  | £500,000. Investor receives 50% income tax relief.                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Target profile</b> | Angels with Highland / community connection and wellness enthusiasts. £10–50k per investor, 4–10 person syndicate.                                                                                     |
| <b>Valuation</b>      | Pre-money likely £250,000–£400,000 (mid-range, realistic for pre-revenue asset-backed business).                                                                                                       |
| <b>Dilution limit</b> | Give away no more than 30% equity at seed stage.                                                                                                                                                       |

### Grant Stack (target £15k–£50k, stack multiple)

| Fund                           | Amount             | Key hook                                               |
|--------------------------------|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| HIE Small Innovation Grant     | Up to £15,000      | Low-friction. First port of call.                      |
| HIE Green Grant Fund           | Up to 50% of costs | Off-grid, wood-fired, remote/rural.                    |
| HC Community Regeneration Fund | £20,000–£50,000    | Community dividend, placemaking, overtourism response. |
| HIE Tourism / Business Support | Variable           | Economic impact, quality jobs, Gaelic culture.         |

## Key Grant Levers

- 01 Community priority pricing (written into articles)
- 02 Local supplier / Highland craftspeople build
- 03 Gaelic language & culture (explicit HIE / Scottish Govt priority)
- 04 Health & wellbeing (mental health, social prescribing)
- 05 Year-round / shoulder season (Highland Council tourism strategy)
- 06 Environmental / net zero (wood-fired, off-grid, solar)
- 07 Coastal / beach activation
- 08 Responsible tourism / overtourism response
- 09 Quality fair-work jobs (Living Wage, year-round, local)

## 09 Financials (High Level)

### Setup Costs

| Configuration            | Cost range                          |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| 1 sauna (mid-commercial) | £18,000–£35,000 inc. supporting kit |
| 2 saunas                 | £35,000–£65,000                     |
| 3 saunas                 | £55,000–£100,000                    |
| Bespoke Kiln-style build | £30,000–£40,000+ per unit           |

### Ongoing Costs per Sauna per Year

| Line item         | Annual cost                                         |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Staff             | £10,000–£18,000                                     |
| Firewood          | £600–£1,200 (very low; key advantage of wood-fired) |
| Insurance         | £800–£1,500                                         |
| Site licence      | £500–£3,000                                         |
| Maintenance       | £500–£1,500                                         |
| Marketing/booking | £500–£1,500                                         |
| Total             | £12,900–£26,700 / sauna / year                      |

### Revenue Projection (2 Saunas, Realistic)

|                             |                                  |                                 |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| ~£90k<br>GROSS REVENUE / YR | £40–60k<br>NET PROFIT BEFORE TAX | 3–5 yrs<br>CAPEX PAYBACK PERIOD |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------|---------------------------------|

### Competitor Pricing Benchmarks

| Operator         | Pricing                       |
|------------------|-------------------------------|
| Applecross Sauna | £15 public / £75 private hire |



| Operator                       | Pricing                                             |
|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Wild Scottish Sauna            | £16 social / £105 for 55 min private (10–12 people) |
| Sauna on Wheels (Fire & Steam) | Similar range                                       |

## 10 Technology & Operations

|                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Website</b>        | Squarespace or Wix with embedded booking system preferred over Shopify (unless branded merchandise, such as robes and sauna hats, is a meaningful revenue line, in which case Shopify wins).                                                                                                     |
| <b>Booking</b>        | FareHarbor, Rezdy, or Acuity (Staffin Sea Sauna uses Acuity). Must handle timed slots, capacity management, cancellations and automated reminders.                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>MVP platform</b>   | React / Vite / TypeScript / Tailwind. Client-side prototype on Netlify (repo: charles-sauna/mvp). Key features in build: local vs. visitor pricing tiers verified against Skye postcode districts IV41–IV56, community session blocks, weather/fire-ban cancellation logic, waitlist management. |
| <b>Cost at launch</b> | ~£20–40/month platform + £30–80/month booking software.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |

## 11 Growth Strategy

- 01 Launch 2 saunas on Skye simultaneously (Portree + TBC second site)
- 02 Reinvest profits to fund third Skye sauna
- 03 Use SEIS raise + grant stack to accelerate to 3 saunas faster
- 04 Build brand and membership base on Skye
- 05 Expand to West Coast mainland (Applecross, Torridon, Ardnamurchan, Kintyre); Gaelic brand works equally across the Gàidhealtachd

Longer-term question: UK-wide consolidation / roll-up model (acquiring 51% stakes in existing community sauna operators); franchise/licensing model; or building the booking platform as standalone SaaS infrastructure, analogous to building Shopify rather than being a retailer. PE consolidation of this space likely within a 2–3 year window.

## 12 Key External Contacts

|                                                 |                                                                 |
|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Highland Council Harbourmaster (Portree)</b> | Site discussions, planning pre-application                      |
| <b>Portree &amp; Braes Community Trust</b>      | Social licence, community alignment at Site 1                   |
| <b>Kyle Harbour Master</b>                      | Broadford pier, 01599 534589                                    |
| <b>MacLeod Estate Pier Master</b>               | Dunvegan pier, 01470 521206 · pier@dunvegancastle.com           |
| <b>CMAL Surplus Sites</b>                       | Uig old terminal, uigsite@cmassets.co.uk                        |
| <b>Crown Estate Scotland / Bidwells</b>         | Foreshore licence (if required), scotland-marine@bidwells.co.uk |
| <b>NatureScot</b>                               | SSSI / NSA / SAC designations check per site                    |
| <b>Highland Council Planning</b>                | Pre-application enquiry, all sites                              |
| <b>HMRC</b>                                     | SEIS Advance Assurance application, before issuing any shares   |
| <b>HIE</b>                                      | Business support and grant officer                              |
| <b>Staffin Sea Sauna operator</b>               | Partnership / coexistence conversation                          |
| <b>SEPA</b>                                     | Water quality self-assessment for plunge sites                  |

### *Blàths à fuachd.*

*This document covers the Skye sauna project only. Maintained separately from other projects. Last updated June 2026.*